



PHOTO BY HEMANT MISHRA

‘THE REAL FEAR IS IRRELEVANCE’

Ravi Venkatesan

► **VENKATESAN BELIEVES LEADERS** must build what he calls a “portfolio life” — an evolving collection of projects, interests, and contributions that creates meaning beyond any single designation.

“Work can be conceptualised as an evolving collection of projects,” he says. “It offers far more flexibility to shape work around the way you want to live, rather than the other way around.”

This used to be something people figured out post-retirement. Not anymore. With people living

longer and traditional employment becoming less stable, many leaders would need to build a portfolio much sooner, says Venkatesan.

“Over time, I realised identity has to exist independently of temporary roles like CEO or institution builder,” he says.

That shift, he believes, is rarely easy. Many senior executives underestimate how deeply their sense of self is tied to their roles. The real fear, according to him, is not financial insecurity, but irrelevance. “Work is about much more than putting food on the table,” he says. “Without it, many people struggle with a surprisingly simple question: how do you explain who you are?”

But purpose, he insists, does not disappear when a corporate role ends. “It can be fulfilled outside a job, often in ways more aligned with personal values.”

Today, Venkatesan’s work spans entrepreneurship,

climate action, and artificial intelligence (AI). He chairs the Global Energy Alliance for People and Planet and the Global Alliance for Mass Entrepreneurship, and is in the process of launching the Institute for Human Flourishing (IHF), a research-action-policy lab focused on ensuring artificial intelligence raises incomes, expands agency, and creates opportunity at scale.

The idea of retiring between 60 and 65 years strikes him as increasingly obsolete. “The real question is whether people remain intellectually engaged, socially connected, physically active, and purposeful.”

Rather than viewing ageing as decline, he sees it as another opportunity for reinvention and new adventures. That, ultimately, is the idea behind a portfolio life: work that fits around living, rather than consuming it entirely.